CONFEDERATE INFANTRYMAN

The American Civil War was an unequal contest, the Confederacy fighting at a great disadvantage in terms of manpower and resources. But at least for the first two years of the conflict, despite undergoing privations and hardship, the Southerners often outfought the Union forces, showing aggression, commitment, and superior leadership. By the end of the war, over a million soldiers had served in the Confederate ranks. Some 260,000 of them died in combat or of disease – almost one in four of those who took part. The Confederates' outstanding general, Robert E. Lee, was unstinting in his praise of his men's fighting qualities, stating: "Their courage in battle entitles them to rank with the soldiers of any army and of any time."

The Confederate army was created virtually out of nothing, in much the same manner as the Union forces. Volunteers stampeded to enlist, inspired by dreams of glory and convinced of the rightness of their cause. Some 200,000 soldiers were enrolled in the first four months of the war. As in the North, companies and regiments were mostly formed on a local basis under the leadership of individuals of wealth and standing, and company officers and NCOs were initially elected by the men. The Confederacy benefited, however, from a substantial leaven of regular army officers who resigned from the US forces to fight for secession.

COMMITTED REBELS

Given its shortage of manpower, the Confederacy, in 1862, was forced to resort to conscription, but they succeeded in making the draft work better than the Union ever did. All white males aged between 18 and 35 were liable for military service and no one could pay for a substitute to take his place. Confederate soldiers were predominantly farmers or farm hands, and unlike the Union troops, very few were foreign-born.

> "CONFEDERATES HAD GONE DOWN AS THE GRASS FALLS BEFORE THE SCYTHE."
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> JOURNALIST **CHARLES COFFIN** DESCRIBES THE AFTERMATH OF THE BATTLE OF ANTIETAM, 17 SEPTEMBER, 1862

It was widely agreed that the Southern soldiers fought with greater dash and enthusiasm than the stubborn, pragmatic Northerners. Their shrill "rebel yell" struck dread into hearts of their enemies during an attack. The Confederate soldier generally felt a greater commitment to the war than the average Union soldier. Confederates felt they were fighting in defence of home and family, and of their entire way of life. Lee expressed the feelings of most of his men when, in 1864, he declared: "If victorious, we have everything to hope for; if defeated, nothing will be left for us to live for." In the last two years of the war, with defeat looming, the Confederate army was swept by religious revivalism, with many soldiers engaging enthusiastically in prayer meetings and hymn-singing.



Holding the Line at All Hazards
Confederate soldiers, despite being outnumbered for much of the time, held their positions heroically.